

START HERE

**How to get off the street in Orange
County. One step at a time.**

You do not need money, a phone, or an
ID to start.

FREE — TAKE IT

nextaddress.org

Six things. Check them off.

- | | | |
|--------------------------|-------------------|------|
| ☐ | A mailing address | p.6 |
| ☐ | A food card | p.9 |
| ☐ | A bus pass | p.9 |
| ☐ | A cell phone | p.10 |
| ☐ | An email address | p.11 |
| ☐ | A photo ID | p.15 |

With all six you can take a job, rent a room, open a bank account, and be reached. Without them you cannot, no matter how hard you work.

HOW TO USE THIS

Start at page 3. Do what that page says. Come back and do the next one. **You will not do all of this today.** Today you do page 3.

Water, a bathroom, food.

Walk into a gas station, a fast food place, or a library. Ask for a cup of tap water. Ask to use the bathroom.

Ask plain. Do not tell your story. “Can I get a cup of water?”

Free meals are served near you every day. No ID. No money. Ask a church, a library worker, a fire station, or a homeless person who looks settled in.

WHAT WILL STOP YOU

Some will say no. That is normal. Ask the next place. It is not about you. Meals run on a clock — if you miss one, ask where the next one is.

Borrow a phone.

You do not need your own phone yet. You need five minutes on someone else's.

“Can you call 2-1-1 for me and let me talk?”

Ask in this order:

- A store clerk
- A librarian
- A fire station. They will not turn you away, and they will give you water.

WHAT WILL STOP YOU

Some will say no. Ask three people. One will say yes. Get a pen from one of them.

STEP 2 — SAY THIS

“I am homeless right now. I am standing at

_____.”

I do not have — **circle what is true:**

a phone

an ID

money

anywhere to sleep

I need outreach and a shelter referral.”

ASK THESE FOUR. WRITE IT HERE WHILE THEY TALK.

1. CAN OUTREACH COME TO ME? WHEN?

2. WHERE DO I WALK TO TODAY?

3. WHERE DO I EAT AND SHOWER?

4. WHERE CAN I GET MAIL?

Get a pen before you call. You will forget every address they say.

Get a mailing address.

Your food card, your phone, your birth certificate and your ID all come in the mail.

**With no address, none of it reaches you.
Nothing else in this book works until this works.**

At any homeless service office, ask: **“Do you hold mail here? Can I use this as my address?”**

THEN STAY NEAR IT.

This is now your home base. Sleep, eat and ask for help within walking distance of it. Drifting to another city means starting this whole book over.

WHAT WILL STOP YOU

Not every place holds mail. If they do not, ask them who does. Then go there.

Get on the list.

“Can you put me into Coordinated Entry?”

- That is the county list for housing.
- If they say they are not the right office, ask them to refer you — and to call while you stand there.
- Give them the mailing address from page 6.

Today’s date is the most valuable thing you own.

How long you have been homeless decides who gets a room first. Every week you wait to do this is a week you lose.

WHAT WILL STOP YOU

Nothing happens fast. Weeks, not days. You will probably not get a bed tonight. Keep going anyway.

When they say no.

You will be told no a lot. It is almost never about you. It is about a bed count, a closed office, or a rule.

**Never leave on a no. Ask one more question:
“Then who does?”**

- Ask three people before you believe an answer.
- Do not walk somewhere far on a maybe. Call first and make sure it is open.
- Your body is the only thing you own that gets you anywhere. Do not spend a whole day on a closed door.

DO NOT DO THIS YET

Not a job site. Not a day of panhandling. Both burn your body, and neither works until you have the six things on page 2.

One visit. Three asks.

Same caseworker, same hour.

1 — FOOD CARD (CALFRESH)

Money for food. Apply with no home, no job, no ID. If you have almost nothing it comes in days.

2 — COUNTY CASH (GENERAL RELIEF)

Small monthly cash for adults with no income. Enough for fare and copies.

3 — BUS PASS

Many agencies hand these out. They will not offer. Ask out loud. A pass means three offices a day instead of one.

Get the food card first. Being on it is what makes the free phone on page 10 possible.

WHAT WILL STOP YOU

These come with appointments. Miss one and it stops. Write every date on page 16.

Ask for California LifeLine.

Say it by name: **“I want to sign up for California LifeLine.”** It pays for monthly phone service, and most companies in it give you a phone.

- **If you got the food card, you already qualify.** That is why page 9 comes first.
- You sign up through a phone company in the program, not the state.
- A caseworker knows which ones. Ask them to sit with you.

A phone is not a luxury here. Nobody can offer you a bed, a job, or an appointment if they have no way to reach you.

WHAT WILL STOP YOU

They will ask for an address — use the one from page 6. They may ask for ID. If you have none yet, say so and ask the caseworker which company takes other proof. Do not walk away.

Get an email address.

This is the only address you own. It does not care where you slept. Nobody can take it, and it never changes.

If you already have one and can still get into it, write it on page 16 and skip ahead.

If you do not have one:

- Go into a library. Say: **“I need help setting up an email address.”**
- It is free. It takes about ten minutes. A librarian will walk you through it.
- Use your real name in it. An employer is going to read it.

WHAT WILL STOP YOU

The password. Write the address **and** the password on page 16 the moment you make it. Locked out is the same as never having one.

Get clean. Ask every day.

- Service centers have showers and laundry. Ask for a hygiene kit and clean clothes.
- Clean changes how people treat you at every desk you walk up to. This is not about pride. It is about getting a yes.
- Ask about a shelter bed **every single day**. Beds open when someone leaves.

If there is no bed: sleep where there is light and where other people are. Keep your papers and your phone on your body, not in a bag.

DO NOT DO THIS YET

Do not go stand at a job site and do not spend your days panhandling. Both burn the only thing you have — your body — and both come after the six things on page 2.

Three papers, in order.

A job, a room and a bank account all need one card: a state ID. To get it you need two papers first.

1 Birth certificate

2 Social Security card

3 State ID card

WHAT WILL STOP YOU

This takes weeks. Start it now and let it run while you do everything else.

Do you have a photo ID?

An expired one counts. A jail or prison ID counts.

YES

Keep it on your body, not in a bag.
You are past the hardest part. **Go to page 16.**

NO

Turn the page.

Ask for a DL 933.

Say to a homeless service worker: **“I need a DL 933 signed.”** One signature does two jobs — your ID card becomes **free**, and it counts as your proof that you live in California.

The DMV needs four things. The DL 933 covers two.

- Proof of who you are — usually a birth certificate
- Your Social Security number
- ~~Proof you live in California~~ — DL 933
- ~~The fee~~ — DL 933

Nobody skips the birth certificate. Born in California? Yours is free — the same worker signs that form too. Born in another state? It costs money and takes longer. Ask for the book.

WHAT WILL STOP YOU

The DL 933 expires. Get it signed when you are ready to go to the DMV, not months early. The free birth certificate form must also be notarized — ask that office to help before you leave.

WRITE IT DOWN

MY MAILING ADDRESS

MY PHONE NUMBER

MY EMAIL & PASSWORD

MY CASEWORKER & NEXT APPOINTMENT

WHERE IS THE REST?

This card is the first part. There is a whole book that goes further. Ask whoever gave you this card, or call 2-1-1 and ask who hands out the book.

Is something in here wrong? Caseworkers and readers: tell us at **fix@nextaddress.org** and the next printing gets fixed.

2-1-1 — help, any hour, free

9-8-8 — if you are in crisis

PRINTED

Phone numbers last. Addresses change.

NEXT ADDRESS